RECORDS OF THE OBERLIN FILE, WRITINGS BY AND ABOUT (Group 21)

[32] Records of the Oberlin File, Writings By and About, 1833-1988, 8 ft. 3 in.

Historical Note

The Oberlin file consists of historical material received piecemeal and from sources that do not fit into existing groups. Some items may be alienated documents. The contents of these files lack organic relationships except in the broadest sense, and they run the gamut from manuscripts to printed or otherwise duplicated materials. Included are letters, essays, poetry, notes, memoranda, legal documents, articles, talks, recollections, clippings, tracts, reports, drawings, etc.

Scope and Content

This collection is divided into three areas: writings by Oberlin people, writings about Oberlin people, and other types of writings concerning Oberlin. Subjects cover Oberlin life for women throughout the years, as well as abolition, Charles G. Finney, the Wellington Rescue, temperance, the Underground Railroad, and the Graham Diet. There are writings by black Oberlin women students and autobiographical accounts of female students, including educator and lecturer Florence May Snell (1861-1949), Class of 1893. Accounts of women missionaries to China, India, and other nations also exist. The graduation essays and addresses by and about women are among the richest items. This file offers excellent supplemental documentation for other Oberlin archival collections.

RECORDS OF THE OBERLIN KINDERGARTEN AND PRIMARY-TRAINING SCHOOL (Group 24)

[33] Records of the Oberlin Kindergarten and Primary-Training School, 1894-1933, 9 ft. 3 in.

Historical Note

Aided by Nancy Squire of the Mutual Benefit Association, 13 women organized themselves to establish a kindergarten-teacher training school in 1894. At a public meeting, a committee known as the Oberlin Kindergarten Association (OKA) was appointed to secure funds and to develop a kindergarten and a teacher training school. This goal was achieved within a year by creating two kindergartens and by naming Beade Goodman principal. Students *of* the training school were interns in the two Oberlin kindergartens and in neighboring school districts. Graduates of the training school taught in many states, as well as in foreign countries. By 1933, when the last class graduated, graduates numbered over a thousand. Although the Oberlin Kindergarten Training School (OKTS) still drew large numbers of students, changing state standards in kindergarten and primary education forced a merger with Oberlin College. These new state regulations required the training school to become a four-year school in order to remain a separate institution. Instead, the OKTS board decided to merge the school with Oberlin College. The Alumni Association of Oberlin College voted to extend membership to the graduates and former students of the OKTS.

Scope and Content

The collection, which is divided in seven records series, documents advancements in the training of kindergarten and primary-school teachers during the late 19th century and the first quarter of the 20th century. The details of the creation and maturation of the kindergarten and primary schools are in the minutes of the Oberlin Kindergarten Association, 1894-1932. Financial records exist for the years 1900 to 1932. Among the reports, 1899-1916, is one to the president of the association stating the status of graduates and discussing the problems facing the OKTS and kindergarten-teacher training in the United States. Three reviews written about the training school during the 1920s are in the files. There are also compiled lists of presidents of the OKA, 1894-1914, and a list of training-school graduates, 1896-1933. Although the files typically concern the graduates of the OKTS, 1896-1933, the collection also contains several manuscripts of Clara May (1872-1957), an 1894 graduate of Oberlin College who became principal of the OKTS. May translated G. Sergi's "Some Ideas on Education" from *Nuova Antologia*, and she wrote "The Montessori System" and bibliography, 1916. Also included are documents covering Clara May's teaching methods and her correspondence with Helen H. Parkhurst (d. 1959), the United States Montessori supervisor.

RECORDS OF THE YOUNG WOMEN'S CHRISTIAN ASSOCIATION (Group 29)

[34] Records of the Young Women's Christian Association, 1899 (1940-58) -1962, 6 ft. 9 in.

Historical Note

The Oberlin YWCA was formed in 1894, when Lucy Wilson (1862-1925) led a group of young women to request the leadership of the weekly prayer meeting. This role formerly had been left to the dean of women. Three years later, Florence Fitch (1875-1951) directed Oberlin into the national Young Women's Christian Association (YWCA) movement.

The governance of the YWCA rested with an elected executive board and with committees responsible for various activities. The YWCA reported to the Women's Board and an advisory board. The latter was composed mainly of female faculty members and wifes of faculty members. By 1904, a general secretary was hired to handle the administrative tasks of the organization.

During the next 70 years the YWCA was active in many town and College activities. Over the years the YWCA worked with the YMCA on many social functions. Although during its early years membership was restricted to women who had an evangelical-church background, in the late 1920s the YWCA opened membership to any woman of Christian faith. The membership was consistently large and peaked in 1945 with 706 women. By 1953 the YWCA had developed five commissions to oversee the various functions of the organization: Religious Emphasis, Campus Life, Community Service, Public Affairs, and Publicity. With the closing of the Graduate School of Theology, the YWCA and YMCA took on the responsibility of religious life at Oberlin. During President Robert K. Carr's administration, the board of trustees expanded religious activities on campus and established an Office of Chaplains, which among other responsibilities, oversaw the YWCA. In 1973 the YMCA/YWCA became defunct.

Scope and Content

The collection documents the purpose and activities of the YWCA. Among the minutes of the organization are those of the advisory board (1928-1944, 1958-1961) and those of the cabinet